

Keeping Secrets the Talisman way

Talisman hooks into a Git repository to validate the outgoing change set for things that look suspicious, like potential SSH keys, authorisation tokens, private keys, etc. It can scan the source code to catch potential problems in embedded source code and documentation. This tool can help prevent major disasters related to security.

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Version control software (VCS) is an essential part of almost all modern software development practices. Software like Git allows developers and quality analysts to save their project history to enable better collaboration, revert to previous states and recover from unintended code changes. These tools allow multiple developers to safely work on the same project and provide significant benefits even if sharing their work with others is not required. With the many benefits of keeping your code in source control, it is equally important for some assets to be kept out of your repository.

Some of the most important assets are sensitive data like passwords, secrets and private keys which should never be checked into a repository unprotected, for security reasons. Overlooking this may result in organisations having to pay out heavy compensations, and from the individual perspective, lead to a loss of privacy or more. One of the recent incidents was Uber's secrets breach, which should give you an idea about how far this could go, if not taken care of early.

According to Bloomberg, "Uber's 2016 breach occurred when hackers discovered that the company's developers had published code that

included their user names and passwords on a private account of the software repository GitHub. Those credentials gave the hackers immediate access to the developers' privileged accounts on Uber's network and with it, access to sensitive Uber servers hosted on Amazon's servers, including the rider and driver data they stole."

As mentioned by CNBC, "Uber has agreed to pay US\$ 148 million in connection with a 2016 data breach and subsequent cover-up, according to the California Attorney General's office." If this convinces you about the importance of keeping secrets away from version control software, it will delight you to